

Youth & Peacebuilding in Sri Lanka

*An analysis of the active contribution and future vision of youth towards a more peaceful and
coexistent society.*

SRI LANKA NATIONAL YOUTH PEACE FORUM

Introduction: Context & Purpose

The Post-War Landscape

Following decades of civil war ending in 2009, Sri Lanka still faces deep ethnic and socio-political fault lines. Realizing sustainable peace requires addressing the underlying systemic grievances of all communities rather than just maintaining a negative peace.

The Imperative of Youth

Traditional policy cycles historically sidelined youth, treating them as passive beneficiaries or instigators of unrest. However, the future of national reconciliation lies in mobilizing young people as active primary stakeholders and leaders in social integration.

| Demographic Potential

23%

Youth Representation

Youth is the Foundation of Peace

The youth population between the ages of 15 and 29 in Sri Lanka represents a significantly large percentage of the total population.

By utilizing this massive human capital positively, they can be transformed into the true pioneers of achieving reconciliation and long-term sustainable peace in the country.

Source: Department of Census and Statistics

UN Resolution 2250

International Recognition

United Nations Security Council Resolution 2250 (UNSCR 2250) officially recognizes at an international level the essential importance of the active, creative, and meaningful participation of youth in peace and security processes.

The Sri Lankan Context

This resolution is highly relevant to Sri Lanka, a country with decades of war experience. Re-emergence of conflicts can be successfully prevented by systematically integrating the youth voice, starting from the community level up to national policy-making.

Three Areas of Contribution



1. Live Dialogues

Developing mutual understanding and coexistence by overcoming the social distance that exists between different ethnicities and religions.



2. Digital Activism

Minimizing the misuse of social media and socialising positive messages regarding reconciliation, equality, and national unity.



3. Community Leadership

Advocating for peace, justice, and human rights at rural and urban levels in collaboration with civil organizations.

| Intercultural Bridge

Language & Cultural Bridge

Breaking Social Stereotypes: By getting to know one another, youth belonging to different cultures can dispel old suspicions and hatred.

Exchange Programs: Youth camps and sports festivals bridging the North and the South pave the way to build a common Sri Lankan identity.

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| Digital Peacebuilding

Positive Power of Technology

Combating Hate Speech: The youth generation must take the lead in identifying religious and racist statements spreading online and reporting factual information against them.

Creating Peaceful Content: Educating society on the beauty of multiculturalism through short videos, art, and social media campaigns.

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| Transforming Education



Peace Education in School Curriculums:

Practically teaching conflict management, human rights, empathy, and respect for diversity starting from the school classroom level.



University Student Activism:

Establishing an intellectual youth discourse within society that can influence policymakers through academic research, debates, and peace forums.



A Culture Free of Violence:

Active contribution of youth leadership to completely eradicate violent cultures, such as ragging, within universities and higher education institutions.

Levels of Contribution

Level of Activity	Main Focus and Role	Community Impact
Regional Level	Rural youth clubs, cultural festivals, and sports organizations.	Building daily mutual trust among different communities.
Provincial Level	Regional peace committees and youth policy consultations (e.g., Youth4Youth).	Including the needs of the youth community into local government decisions.
National Level	National Youth Parliament, reconciliation commissions, and policy-making.	Blending the youth voice into the legal system and state-level decisions.

Youth Challenges



According to survey data, the biggest barriers faced by youth peace activists in Sri Lanka are the lack of active political support and the lack of adequate financial facilities for youth organizations.

Conclusion: The Way Forward



Policy Mainstreaming:

Integrating structured youth feedback mechanisms directly into national constitutional reforms and local peace advisory councils.



Sustainable Funding Pools:

Allocating independent budgetary streams to ensure local, grassroots youth peace collectives are sustainably resourced beyond short-term projects.



Safe Dialogic Environments:

Ensuring both physical safety and online data protection safeguards for youth peace builders advocating against structural marginalization.

“Peace is not merely the absence of war. It is a wholesome social environment where justice, equality, and mutual respect exist for everyone. The true and permanent creators of this can only be the youth of the country.”

— SRI LANKA NATIONAL YOUTH PEACE CHARTER

Let's Stand Together for a More Peaceful Tomorrow!

| Image Sources

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https://www.undp.org/sites/g/files/zskgke326/files/2023-02/52401048971_319e161751_o.jpg

Source: www.undp.org

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Source: www.apa.org